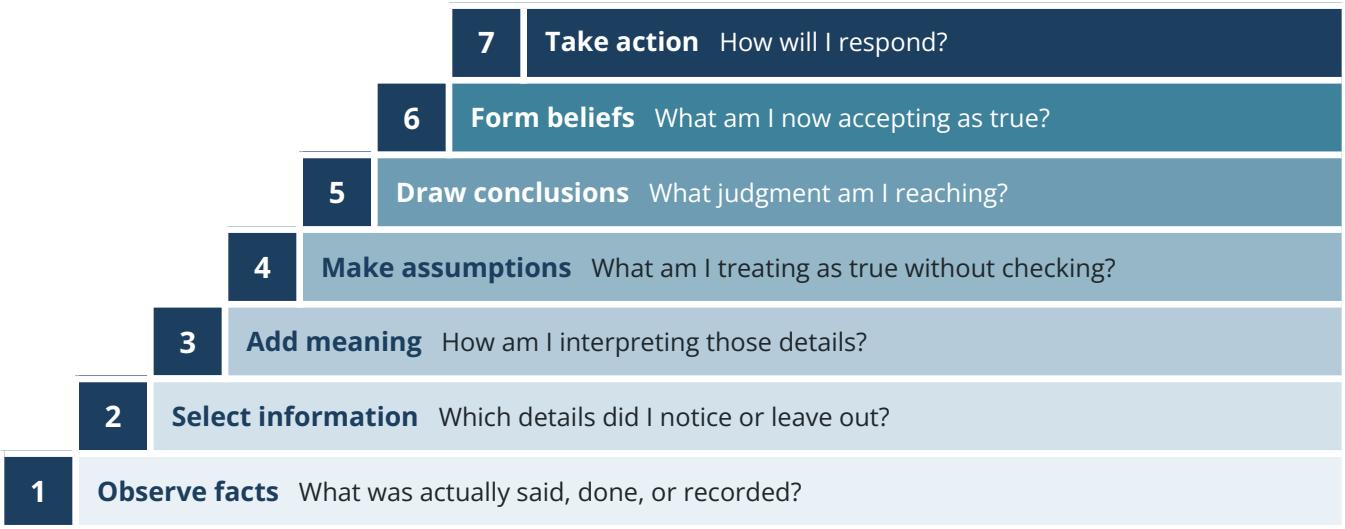
02 | RESOURCE | UNDERSTAND THE TOOL

How the ladder shapes a decision

The full seven-rung model, applied to everyday DSS work.

The Ladder of Inference describes the path from what we observe to how we act. The steps can happen quickly. The model helps us notice where an interpretation has become an assumption.



START HERE • Read from 1 at the bottom to 7 at the top.

The feedback loop

Our beliefs influence what we notice next. Believing that someone never responds may make a delay stand out while we overlook their earlier reply. Look for evidence that challenges your first explanation.

> **Use the model to check yourself, not label someone else**
> Describe the words or actions you observed. Ask a neutral question. Listen for information that changes your view. A conclusion can be reasonable and still need verification.

Training basis: Decision & Escalation, final Supervisor edition, slides 8–9. Model: Trevor Maber, TED-Ed, "Rethinking thinking."

Learn more: TED-Ed lesson | USC explanation of the seven steps

02 | RESOURCE | PUT IT TO WORK

Turn an assumption into a useful question

Illustrative workplace example. This is not a report of an actual County incident.

Part of the ladder	What might happen
1–2. Facts and selection	A supervisor replies, "Please send your recommendation." You focus on the request but may not know what information the supervisor still needs.
3–4. Meaning and assumptions	You interpret the reply as a brush-off and assume the decision has already been made. Neither point was stated.
5–7. Conclusion, belief, action	You conclude your input will not matter, believe the process is pointless, and delay the request or send a frustrated response.

A better next step

> **Ask a question that can change the decision**
> "I can prepare a recommendation. Which decision needs to be made, what facts should I include, and when is the recommendation needed?"

Then confirm your responsibility and authority. You may own the research or recommendation while someone else owns approval. Share the verified facts, the unresolved question, and your recommended next action.

Use this with a current situation

Use this space	Your notes
What I observed	
Assumption / other explanation	
Question / person to ask	
What I will do next	

Notice when your view changes

> *"I first thought _____. After checking _____, I learned _____. My next step is _____."*

Training basis: Decision & Escalation, final Supervisor edition, slides 8–9. Model: Trevor Maber, TED-Ed, "Rethinking thinking."